

Go, Lovely Rose



POEM TEXT

- 1 Go, lovely rose!
- 2 Tell her that wastes her time and me,
- 3 That now she knows,
- 4 When I resemble her to thee,
- 5 How sweet and fair she seems to be.
- 6 Tell her that's young,
- 7 And shuns to have her graces spied,
- 8 That hadst thou sprung
- 9 In deserts, where no men abide,
- 10 Thou must have uncommended died.
- 11 Small is the worth
- 12 Of beauty from the light retired;
- 13 Bid her come forth,
- 14 Suffer herself to be desired,
- 15 And not blush so to be admired.
- 16 Then die! that she
- 17 The common fate of all things rare
- 18 May read in thee;
- 19 How small a part of time they share
- 20 That are so wondrous sweet and fair!



SUMMARY

Go, beautiful rose! Tell the lady who's wasting her time (and mine) that, when I compare her to you, she looks just as lovely as you are.

Tell this young woman, who refuses to let anyone gaze at her beauty, that if you had grown in a wasteland where nobody lives, you'd have died unappreciated.

Beauty that's hidden away from the light isn't worth much. So tell that lady to come out, tolerate being desired, and not act so embarrassed when I admire her.

Then die! Your death will teach her the shared fate of all beautiful things. Lovely women and lovely flowers alike flourish for so short a time!



THEMES



MAKING THE MOST OF YOUTH AND BEAUTY

"Go, Lovely Rose" is a classic *carpe diem* poem: a poem in which a male lover cajoles his elusive lady-love into returning his affections, often with warnings that her youth and beauty won't last forever and she'd better make the most of them now. In this poem, the speaker makes his point through a [personified](#) rose. He nominates this flower to be his messenger, telling it to deliver words of flattery and warning to the woman he's got his eye on. This rose—as fragile as it's "lovely"—stands as a reminder that beauty is fleeting and must be enjoyed while it lasts.

The speaker's beloved "wastes her time and me," the speaker complains: she's hiding her loveliness away from the world (and from him in particular), and in doing so she's squandering the best days of her youth and the speaker's youth alike. It's for this reason that he elects to send her a rose as his messenger. A rose can communicate everything he wants her to understand by working as a perfect [symbol](#) of the lady. Like the lady, the rose is "sweet and fair"—and like the lady, the rose wouldn't bring anyone any pleasure if it grew in "deserts, where no men abide." There's no point being beautiful, the speaker suggests, if one's beauty goes "uncommended," unappreciated and unseen.

But the most ominous way in which this rose is like the lady is in its mortality. Its final role as a messenger, the speaker says, will be to "die," and thus to show the lady a great and terrible truth: it's the "common fate of all things rare" (the shared destiny of all lovely things) to wither away in time. The poem thus comes across as a warning against waste as much as a celebration of a lady's beauty. The speaker's messenger rose serves as a reminder that loveliness—and young love—might be fleeting as a summer flower.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-20



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-5

*Go, lovely rose!
Tell her that wastes her time and me,
That now she knows,
When I resemble her to thee,*

How sweet and fair she seems to be.

The poem begins with a command from a man to a flower. The speaker makes an [apostrophe](#) to a [personified](#) “lovely rose,” treating the flower as his messenger and instructing it to carry his words to his lady love.

Some of those words feel conventionally flattering, exactly the sort of thing one would say to someone they were sending a rose to. The rose must tell the lady, for instance, that when the speaker “resemble[s] her” (or compares her) to the rose itself, she seems just as “sweet and fair.” She’s a veritable blossom.

But this rose isn’t just supposed to carry a compliment to the speaker’s beloved; it’s also meant to work as a persuader. For, as the speaker complains, this lady “wastes her time and me.” In other words, this lady is holding back, being coy, not simply rushing into the speaker’s open arms. And the speaker is fed up with it. His [zeugma](#) on “wastes her time and me” carries a note of threat: in wasting “her time,” the lady might also be wasting her chance with “me,” with this rose-sending lover.

This, then, will be a *carpe diem* (or “seize the day”) poem, a poem in which a frustrated lover tries to talk his beloved into returning his affections. (This genre that was [all the rage](#) in 17th-century England, the time and place when Waller was writing.) Roses [often featured](#) in *carpe diem* poetry, working as [symbols](#) of both love and transience. For roses are as fragile as they’re lovely—and the point of a *carpe diem* poem is that lovely ladies should seize the day, enjoying youth and love while they can, before (like roses) they wither.

In telling this personified rose his message for his lady, this speaker is also speaking directly to his lady. As his inclination to “resemble her” to the rose implies, he sees her as rose-like in precisely that *carpe-diem* sort of way: young, beautiful, and unlikely to remain so forever. And while his first words to her are complimentary, there’s also a hint of danger in them. After all, he doesn’t say that she is as “sweet and fair” as a rose, but that she “seems to be” so. Perhaps she’ll start looking a whole lot less sweet if she keeps on “wast[ing] her time” by dodging the speaker.

This energetic poem will convey its message of mingled flattery and warning in four quintains (five-line stanzas). The varied [meter](#) here swings between [iambic](#) dimeter (lines of two iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in “That **hadst** | thou **sprung**”) and iambic tetrameter (lines of *four* iambs, as in “In **des-** | erts, **where** | no men | **abide**”), giving the poem jaunty energy. Often, the speaker heightens that energy even more through little changes in the meter. Take the rhythm of the poem’s very first line:

Go, love- | ly rose!

The first foot there is a [spondee](#)—a powerful DUM-DUM. The punch of that first “Go” starts the poem with a bang, helping to

capture the speaker’s frustration and longing.

LINES 6-10

*Tell her that’s young,
And shuns to have her graces spied,
That hadst thou sprung
In deserts, where no men abide,
Thou must have uncommended died.*

The speaker continues his instructions to the rose with some emphatic [anaphora](#). Just as he instructed the rose to “Tell her who wastes her time and me” that she’d better pull herself together and accept his affections, he now instructs it to “Tell her that’s young” that it’s no good hiding away forever. Those paired commands make the speaker sound both powerful and agitated: he’s just piling on the things this lady needs to be told.

His problem is that the lady “shuns to have her graces spied.” In other words, she won’t even let the speaker get a *glimpse* of her. That, the speaker insists, is no good. He explains why through another comparison between lady and rose: the rose’s very nature becomes the message here.

In the first stanza, the speaker observes that the rose and the lady alike are “sweet and fair.” Now, he makes the point that sweetness and fairness don’t do anyone any good if they’re hidden away. For, if the rose had grown “in deserts, where no men abide”—in an unpopulated wasteland—then it would have “died” completely “uncommended,” unappreciated. Beauty, in other words, can’t have any pleasant effect on the world (or enjoy its own effects on others!) if it goes unseen. The rose is clearly meant to convey two ideas at once: *Dear lady, you are the loveliest*, and *Dear lady, you’re wasting everyone’s time when you hide yourself away from me*.

An [enjambment](#) helps to evoke the frustration behind this flattery:

That hadst thou **sprung**
In deserts, where no men abide,

This odd line break—falling at a place where one would never pause in ordinary speech—puts a little extra stress on the already energetic word “sprung,” but also hustles the line along impatiently.

LINES 11-15

*Small is the worth
Of beauty from the light retired;
Bid her come forth,
Suffer herself to be desired,
And not blush so to be admired.*

The speaker underscores his vision of the rose withering away in the desert by spelling his point out: “Small is the worth / Of beauty from the light retired,” he proclaims. Beauty is made to

be seen. His idea about beauty works rather like the old question, “If a tree falls in the forest and there’s no one there to hear it, does it make a sound?” Beauty that no one sees might barely be beauty at all. These lines might feel stern, but there’s a touch of wistfulness in them, too: the long /i/ [assonance](#) in “beauty from the light retired” has a light, sad music.

That lasts only for a moment, however, before the speaker launches back into messages for the rose to carry to the lady:

Bid her come forth,
Suffer herself to be desired,
And not blush so to be admired.

The command “Bid her” picks up on the “Tell her” [parallelism](#) from earlier in the poem, but with more punch. So far, the speaker has commanded the rose to tell the lady that she’s “sweet and fair” and that roses that grow in empty wastelands don’t get properly appreciated. Now, his words are more forceful and direct. The rose is to tell the lady to “come forth,” to “suffer herself to be desired” (to tolerate being wanted), and to stop “blush[ing]”—that is, to stop acting so bashful about the fact that he wants her.

These words add something new to this poem’s tone. Many *carpe diem* poems, while making similar arguments about the need to enjoy youth and beauty while the getting’s good, don’t reveal too much about *why* the lady might be hiding. (In the 17th-century context most of these poems were written in, readers might guess that the ladies have very good reasons to dodge their lovers: women would lose their precious reputations if it were known that they’d had sex before marriage, and speakers like [Marvell’s](#) and [Herrick’s](#) definitely have sex on the brain.) But this speaker implies that this lady might be rather innocent and shy, not just scrupulously virtuous. The mere *idea* of being “desired,” he implies, makes her blush.

Perhaps, however, this is all part of the speaker’s scheme. In this section of his message, he seems to say: *It’s not so dangerous to come out and let someone simply admire your beauty, is it? What could go wrong?*

LINES 16-20

*Then die! that she
The common fate of all things rare
May read in thee;
How small a part of time they share
That are so wondrous sweet and fair!*

As the final stanza begins, the speaker tells his rose-messenger the final part of its mission: “Then die!” After telling the lady that she’s as beautiful as it is, that such beauty shouldn’t hide away unappreciated, and that she should therefore come on out and “suffer herself to be desired,” the rose must wither away, demonstrating the “common fate of all things rare” (that

is, the shared destiny of all lovely things). The rose isn’t just like the lady because they’re both “sweet and fair,” then, but also because they’re both mortal. In its loveliness and its fragility, this messenger-flower is a [symbol](#) of the lady herself.

The speaker describes the end of the rose’s kamikaze mission in three swift [enjambéd](#) lines:

Then die! that she
The common fate of all things rare
May read in thee;

These enjambments, like those from earlier in the poem, hustle the reader along with special momentum; the speaker delivers the final part of the rose’s task at impassioned speed.

The poem’s closing [couplet](#), however, feels more thoughtful:

How small a part of time they share
That are so wondrous sweet and fair!

It would be easy to read these lines as the culmination of the poem’s not-very-veiled warning: “sweet and fair” things like the lady and the rose *stay* sweet and fair for only a short period of time. (The [repetition](#) of the words “sweet and fair” from the first stanza really leans a pointy elbow on that idea.) But there might be real melancholy here, too. Readers might imagine the speaker delivering these final musings with a sigh, like Shakespeare’s Feste singing “[Youth’s a stuff will not endure](#).” For, after all, the speaker earlier complained that the lady “wastes her time **and me**.” She’s not the only one whose youth is fading away.



SYMBOLS



THE ROSE

The “lovely rose” the speaker sends as a messenger to his lady is an obvious [symbol](#) of the lady herself (and, by extension, of all lovely young people). The speaker makes this point clearly and from the start: “when I resemble [my lady] to thee,” the speaker tells the rose, she looks just as “sweet and fair” as it does.

But if this lady is a lovely rose, she’s also subject to the fate of all roses: an all-too-fast withering-away and death. The rose becomes her symbol because it’s beautiful and fresh, yes, but also because roses bloom and fade over the course of mere days. Women’s youth and beauty, the speaker implies, enjoys just as “small a part of time” as a blossom.

This speaker is *far* from the only pining lover to make this point using a symbolic rose. Speakers in [Shakespeare](#) and [Herrick](#), to name just two poets out of many, likewise simultaneously compliment and threaten ladies with visions of fading flowers.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "Go, lovely rose!"
- **Lines 4-5:** "When I resemble her to thee, / How sweet and fair she seems to be."
- **Lines 8-10:** "hadst thou sprung / In deserts, where no men abide, / Thou must have uncommended died."
- **Lines 16-18:** "Then die! that she / The common fate of all things rare / May read in thee;"

commands front and center—and while the speaker is technically commanding his flowery messenger, he's really commanding his lady *through* the rose, which (as he points out) is basically her mirror image.

That link between lady and rose is underscored by the words that end the poem's first and final stanzas alike:

When I resemble her to thee,
How **sweet and fair** she seems to be.
[...]
How small a part of time they share
That are so wondrous **sweet and fair**!

This echo reminds the lady that she's rose-like in more ways than one. She's beautiful and lovely and fragrant as a rose, all this is true. She's also, rose-like, *mortal*, and if she isn't careful her petals are going to drop before she's gotten the most out of being so "sweet and fair."

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** "Tell her"
- **Line 5:** "sweet and fair"
- **Line 6:** "Tell her"
- **Line 13:** "Bid her"
- **Line 20:** "sweet and fair"

ENJAMBMENT

This poem swings between longer and shorter lines. Striking [enjambments](#) highlight (and sometimes cut across) that changing rhythm, creating a bold, energetic tone. The first of these enjambments occurs between lines 8-9:

That hadst thou **sprung**
In deserts, where no men abide,

This break in the sentence occurs at a place where one wouldn't naturally pause in everyday speech, a choice with two effects:

- It adds special emphasis to the word "sprung"
- It swoops the eye over the line break, lifting the reader from the shorter line into the longer line and lending extra frustrated energy to the speaker's image of the rose in the lonesome wasteland.

There's a similar effect in the enjambment between lines 11-12: "Small is the worth / Of beauty from the light retired" stresses "worth" and swings the reader along into the speaker's argument. But the poem's most pronounced series of enjambments arrives in the first three lines of the last stanza, the speaker's final argumentative salvo:

POETIC DEVICES

APOSTROPHE

This poem is framed as an [apostrophe](#) to a "lovely rose"—a flower that the speaker is sending to a lady as a simultaneous compliment and warning. The speaker [personifies](#) this rose and treats it as a messenger, telling it the idea he wants it to pass along to his lady: that she's as "sweet and fair" as it is, but as fragile and mortal as it is, too. The rose must tell the lady, in short, that she's just like a rose in every way: she's a gorgeous but temporary blossom who will die "uncommended," unadmired, if she insists on hiding away where "no men abide."

The speaker's apostrophe to the rose thus makes the flower a proxy for the lady. Everything the speaker tells the rose to pass along—that beauty does no good if it's hidden "from the light," that "all things rare" (all wonderful, beautiful things) share the "common fate" of death and must thus enjoy their time in the sun while they can—is applicable to blossom and woman alike.

The apostrophe also creates a certain tone of complicity between the speaker and the rose. The rose is the speaker's co-conspirator here, his partner in persuasion.

Where Apostrophe appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-5
- Lines 6-10
- Lines 13-15
- Lines 16-18

REPETITION

All across the poem, the speaker uses [repetitions](#) to drive home his big point: his beloved should stop shunning him and respond to his affections before he and she alike are old and withered. All this echoing language serves a tonal purpose, too, making the speaker sound at once impatient and masterful.

For instance, take the [parallelism](#) that marks the speaker's many instructions to the rose, his messenger. The speaker tells the rose to "Tell her that wastes her time and me" to pull herself together (line 2); to "Tell her that's young" that she'd better not count on being young forever (line 6); to "Bid her come forth" and be "admired" in line 13. All these repeated phrasings put

Then die! that she
The common fate of all things rare
May read in thee;

Here, enjambments spread one idea over three full lines. So far, the speaker's argument has rested on the idea that the beloved's beauty should rightly be shared (and shared with him); with these enjambed lines, he introduces the blunter idea that the beloved and her beauty alike will die one day. The jolting enjambments lend this warning special force.

Where Enjambment appears in the poem:

- **Lines 8-9:** "sprung / In"
- **Lines 11-12:** "worth / Of"
- **Lines 16-17:** "she / The"
- **Lines 17-18:** "rare / May"

ASSONANCE

"Go, lovely rose," like a lot of *carpe diem* poems, uses a funny mixture of flattery and warnings to communicate its message. The poem's musical sounds—particularly its harmonious [assonance](#)—helps to support the "flattery" side of the proceedings, making this poem sound like a romantic serenade even as it warns of decay.

The first stanza provides a wealth of examples:

Go, lovely rose!
Tell her that wastes her time and me,
That now she knows,
When I resemble her to thee,
How sweet and fair she seems to be.

The long /o/ of "Go, lovely rose!" launches the poem with a sound like an echoing sigh: *oh! oh!* Then, the long /e/ sound of "thee," "sweet," "she," "seems," and "be" adds a fittingly sweet harmony to the stanza's closing [couplet](#). (Perhaps, though, that long /e/ also draws attention to a potentially ambivalent word: "she seems to be," but is she?)

There's similar music (on a cheekier note) in lines 8-10:

That hadst thou sprung
In deserts, where no men abide,
Thou must have uncommended died.

Besides sounding nice, the /eh/ sound in these lines supports a little joke, linking "men" to "uncommended"—and perhaps hinting that being commended by *men* in the sense of "male people" (not just the sense of "humanity") is what this lady really needs.

Sometimes, assonance is just plain [euphonious](#)—as in line 12, where the long /i/ of "beauty from the light retired" illuminates

the speaker's language.

Where Assonance appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "Go," "rose"
- **Line 4:** "thee"
- **Line 5:** "sweet," "she seems," "be"
- **Line 9:** "men"
- **Line 10:** "uncommended"
- **Line 12:** "light retired"
- **Line 18:** "read," "thee"



VOCABULARY

Resemble (Line 4) - Compare.

Thee, thou (Line 4, Line 8, Line 10, Line 18) - Old-fashioned ways of saying "you":

- "Thee" is the object form of "you," as in "I want thee to come over here"
- "Thou" is the subject form of "you," as in "Thou art playing hard to get"

Shuns to have her graces spied (Line 7) - Refuses to let anyone see her beauties.

Hadst (Line 8) - Had.

Deserts, where no men abide (Line 9) - Wastelands where no one lives. (A "desert," in this context, isn't a hot sandy place, just any unpopulated region.)

Uncommended (Line 10) - Unappreciated, unpraised.

Retired (Line 12) - Hidden away.

Bid (Line 13) - Tell, command.

Suffer (Line 14) - Allow.

Common (Line 17) - Shared, universal.

Rare (Line 17) - Special, wonderful.

Wondrous (Line 20) - Wonderfully, astonishingly.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Go, Lovely Rose" is what's known as a *carpe diem* poem. That Latin term, which translates to "seize the day," is used to describe poems in which a lover (almost invariably male) pleads with a beloved (almost invariably female) to get the most out of youth and beauty while the getting's good—by which he means that his lady should respond to his romantic advances.

The tone of these poems often falls somewhere between longing, impatient, and threatening. This poem (a famous example of the genre) is no different: the speaker warns his

beloved that she's wasting both "her time and me," and that her attractions won't last any longer than a rose's ephemeral petals. Waller conveys his version of this message over the course of four quintains (five-line stanzas) written in a mixture of short [iambic](#) dimeter lines (lines of two iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "May **read** | in **thee**") and longer iambic tetrameter lines (four iambs, as in "Tell **her** | that **wastes** | her **time** | and **me**"). The varied meter of these stanzas make the poem feel fittingly *frustrated*: rather than cruising along evenly, the rhythm lurches and pulls like a dog on a short leash.

METER

"Go, Lovely Rose" alternates between lines of [iambic](#) dimeter and iambic tetrameter. That means that its shorter lines use two iambs (metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm), as in "May **read** | in **thee**," while its longer lines use four, as in "When I | resem- | ble **her** | to **thee**." The shorter dimeter lines fall on the A rhymes in the poem's ABABB [rhyme scheme](#), and the longer tetrameter lines fall on the B rhymes.

The difference in line lengths here keeps this poem from simply flowing along like a calm stream. There's an abrupt lurch built right into the rhythm, giving the speaker's voice an impatient quality that matches his impatience with his elusive beloved.

Variations in the meter add to that effect. In line 1, for instance, the poem kicks off with a powerful [spondee](#) (a metrical foot with a DUM-DUM rhythm):

Go, love- | ly rose!

The intense stress on "Go" launches the poem with vigor (and perhaps irritation).

Several other lines start with a [trochee](#) (the opposite foot to an iamb, with a DUM-da rhythm): line 11 ("Small is | the **worth**"), line 13 ("Bid her | come **forth**"), and line 14 ("Suffer | herself | to be | desired") all seem to strain forward eagerly with those up-front stresses leading the way. (The first words of lines 2 and 6—"Tell her"—might also be read as trochees, though it's possible to read them as exasperated iambs, too: "Tell **her** | that's **young**" puts more stress on telling that specific "her.")

The cumulative effect here is to make the speaker sound equal parts vigorous and frustrated. This isn't a gentle, mellifluous love poem; it's something livelier.

RHYME SCHEME

The [rhyme scheme](#) of "Go, Lovely Rose" runs as follows, with new rhyme sounds introduced in each stanza:

ABABB

The five-line stanza was a popular form around Waller's time, and other 17th-century poets like [John Donne](#) and [George Herbert](#) used the same pattern of rhyme in their quintains. Here, the rhymes track the poem's rhythms: the A rhymes

always land on a short dimeter line (a line of two beats, as in "That **now** | she **knows**"), and the B rhymes always land on a long tetrameter line (a line of four beats, as in "Tell **her** | that **wastes** | her **time** | and **me**"). The rhyme thus helps to emphasize the poem's swinging rhythm (and the speaker's energetic tone of voice).

That double B rhyme at the end of the stanzas captures something of the speaker's mood, too. There's something insistent in the reiterated sound, especially because those paired closing lines usually make a stern point about the folly of the lady's resistance. The poem's final words—"How small a part of time they **share** / That are so wondrous sweet and **fair**!"—feel particularly potent underscored by that rhymed [couplet](#).



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker is a frustrated lover. Like the speakers of many *carpe diem* poems, he's impatiently asking his lady-love to return his affections before it's too late: she "wastes her time and me," he says, when she "shuns to have her graces spied," when she refuses to come out and be loved.

His is a common refrain in 17th-century British poetry. Waller's speaker joins those of near-contemporaries like [Robert Herrick](#) and [Andrew Marvell](#) in reminding a lady that, while she's gorgeous and fresh and sweet as a rosebud *now*, her time of youth and beauty won't last forever, so she'd better enjoy it while she can—and, more to the point, enjoy it with him.

Readers might thus notice an oddly mixed tone here, as in so many *carpe diem* poems. On the one hand, this speaker praises his lady's beauty in idealized romantic terms: she's as "sweet and fair" as a perfect rose. On the other, the speaker indirectly threatens his lady with the looming prospect of old age and death. A rose that hides away in places "where no men abide," he not-so-subtly hints, is a rose that will wither away and die "uncommended," unappreciated—wasted, in short. The only way his lady can really make the most of her youth and beauty, the speaker thus concludes, is to come out of hiding and "suffer herself to be desired"—endure being admired and pursued.

Like the speaker of many *carpe diem* poems, this fellow has a voice that mingles wit, passion, frustration, and the merest hint of cruelty.



SETTING

There's no clear setting for this poem: it seems to take place in an abstract, idealized world of blushing roses and empty "desert[s]." The subject and form, however, make it clear that this is a poem of its era. *Carpe diem* poems like this one—that is, poems in which a lover urges his reluctant beloved to submit to his romantic advances—were in vogue in 17th-century

England, Edmund Waller's time and place. (This is one example among many from the period: some 17th-century *carpe diem* poems are among the most [famous and beautiful](#) in the English language.)

If readers imagine that the poem is indeed taking place in Waller's own world, its meaning gets a little more complex. The central point of a *carpe diem* poem is that youth and beauty must be enjoyed while they're fresh because they certainly won't last. But the implied conclusion—that the beloved lady should therefore give the speaker the attention he wants—has higher stakes in a culture where women weren't meant to have sex before they were married. The speaker of this poem suggests he wants only to “admire[]” this lady out in the open, but many of his colleagues suggest they're looking for something a [lot more intimate](#) than that.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Edmund Waller (1606-1687) was an English writer and politician whose career spanned the tumultuous years of the English Civil War and the Restoration. He would become one of several poet-politicians involved with the court of King Charles II.

"Go, Lovely Rose" is by far Waller's most famous work, and it fits into a fashionable English poetic tradition of the 17th century: the *carpe diem* poem. These poems, in which a lover urges his beloved to give into his advances while everyone involved is still young and beautiful, were a favorite form for poets from [Robert Herrick](#) to [Andrew Marvell](#). Waller's entry to the genre was first published under the title "Song" in his 1645 collection *Poems*, and [set to music](#), it quickly became popular.

In his life as a member of Parliament, Waller became friends with notable political-literary figures like [Dryden](#) and [Hobbes](#). His elegant versification would go on to inspire the major Enlightenment-era poet [Alexander Pope](#).

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Edmund Waller lived through one of the most dramatic episodes in English history: the English Civil War. In this earthshaking conflict, the Roundheads, led by Oliver Cromwell, rose up against the Cavaliers, forces loyal to King Charles I and to the monarchy in general. Cromwell's Roundheads argued for increased Parliamentary power as a curb on kingly tyranny.

This clash came to a dramatic climax in 1649 when Cromwell's forces tried, convicted, and beheaded Charles I for treason. This execution was a huge shock to a country whose recent

monarchs had proclaimed the "divine right of kings," the idea that kings and queens were appointed by God.

Cromwell's stand against such ideas would start to look ironic when he began to exercise dictatorial control in his role as "Lord Protector." His power and popularity soon waned, and England invited Charles I's exiled son Charles II back to the throne. The young king's return ushered in a period known as the Restoration, an era of luxury, elegance, and wit.

Waller, a politician as well as a poet, was one of many writers who found himself tossed around on the stormy seas of these years. After Charles I was deposed, Waller was convicted of treason for his Royalist sympathies and narrowly escaped execution himself. He was exiled to Europe for nearly a decade, only returning to England when Cromwell (a distant relation of his) invited him. Despite that debt to Cromwell, Waller would go on to become a successful politician and courtier after the Restoration.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of the poem. (<https://youtu.be/gpBlrKNRavw?si=B9MnZ4Pqfxi3QLdp>)
- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn more about Waller. (<https://www.britannica.com/biography/Edmund-Waller>)
- [The Poem Set to Music](#) — Listen to a musical version of this poem. (<https://youtu.be/e9UhHNChNbU?si=lyg07VHEX6S-LTji>)
- [Portraits of Waller](#) — See some images of Waller—as a young man and as an august, bewigged old politician. (<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/person/mp04673/edmund-waller>)



HOW TO CITE

MLA

Nelson, Kristin. "Go, Lovely Rose." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 19 Dec 2023. Web. 8 Apr 2024.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Nelson, Kristin. "Go, Lovely Rose." LitCharts LLC, December 19, 2023. Retrieved April 8, 2024. <https://www.litcharts.com/poetry/edmund-waller/go-lovely-rose>.